

Music Career — Action Plan

Jeffrey Bickish • Acoustic Folk • Sandpoint, Idaho • Year 1: Aug 2026 – Jul 2027

A month-by-month execution plan built for **4–8 hours/week**. Strategy is **content and platform first** — YouTube, website, email list, and Spotify — with gigging as a later complement. You have a home recording setup (Focusrite + condenser mic + DAW) and 13–20 original songs ready to work from.

Key Milestones

- ◆ **Aug 2026** — All platforms set up — website, YouTube, email list, DistroKid
- ◆ **Sept 2026** — Single selected, arranged, and recording underway
- ◆ **Oct 2026** — Single mixed, mastered, and submitted to DistroKid
- ◆ **Nov 2026** — First single released on all streaming platforms
- ◆ **Nov 2026** — 10 YouTube videos published
- ◆ **Feb 2027** — All EP tracks recorded
- ◆ **Apr 2027** — EP mastered and submitted for distribution
- ◆ **May 2027** — Debut EP released — timed for Sandpoint summer
- ◆ **Jun 2027** — First sync licensing submissions + first local gigs with EP credential
- ◆ **Jul 2027** — Year 1 complete — review, reset, plan Year 2

Platform Priority

- **YouTube** — Primary discovery engine. 1 video every 10–14 days. Folk/acoustic thrives here.
- **Website (Bandzoogle, ~\$10/mo)** — Your permanent home. Bio, music, email signup, press kit.
- **Email list (MailerLite, free)** — Most valuable long-term asset. Even 200 real fans beats 2,000 followers.
- **DistroKid (\$22/yr)** — Distributes your music to Spotify, Apple Music, YouTube Music, and 30+ platforms.
- **Spotify for Artists (free)** — Claim after first release. Enables editorial playlist pitching.
- **Instagram (light)** — Claim your handle. Post occasionally. Don't stress this one.
- **TikTok (optional)** — Only if something takes off organically. Zero obligation.
- **Bandcamp (free, 15% fee)** — Set up at EP release. Folk fans love it for direct purchases.

★ *Don't try to be everywhere. Be solid in 4 places: YouTube + Website + Email + Spotify.*

Year 1 — Month by Month

■ = task | ◆ = milestone | ★ = tip or important note

M1

August 2026 | Build Your Digital Home

4–6 hrs/wk

Catalog & Creative

- Listen through all 13–20 original songs — take notes on which feel most finished
- Create a simple spreadsheet: Song title | Status | Recording ready? | Single candidate?
- Identify your top 3 single candidates — most accessible, emotionally clear, ~3 min
- Record rough phone demos of those 3 finalists (just for your own ears)
- Choose your artist name — legal name or stage name — decide now before creating accounts

★ *This decision affects every platform below. Lock it in first.*

Platform Setup

- Sign up for DistroKid (\$22/yr) — don't upload anything yet
- Sign up for Bandzoogle (\$10/mo) — pick a clean template
 - Build 5 pages: Home, Music (empty for now), About, Shows, Contact
 - Write short bio (100 words) and long bio (250 words)
 - Add a good artist photo — outdoors, natural light, guitar optional
- Sign up for MailerLite (free) — create list called 'My Audience'
 - Add email signup form to website Home page AND Music page
- Create YouTube channel — artist name, About section, channel icon + banner (Canva)
- Create Instagram account — claim handle, profile photo, 1-line bio

★ *Don't post anything on Instagram yet — just claim the handle.*

First YouTube Video

- Film and upload your first video — a single-camera acoustic performance of any original
 - Setup: natural window light, phone or camera, your best-sounding room
 - Title format: '[Song Name] — Jeffrey Bickish (Acoustic Folk)'
 - Write a real description: who you are, where you're from, what the song is about

★ *Don't wait for perfect. Real and imperfect beats polished and delayed every time.*

◆ **MILESTONE: All platforms live — website, YouTube, email list, DistroKid account**

M2

September 2026 | Choose & Record Your Single

5–7 hrs/wk

Single Selection & Arrangement

- Commit to ONE song as your first single by end of week 1
- Write out the full arrangement map: intro / verse / chorus / bridge / outro
- Decide on instrumentation: solo guitar+vocals? Light percussion? Harmony vocal?

- Practice the song at least 20 full run-throughs before recording
- Set up your recording space — quiet room, rugs/soft surfaces to reduce echo
- Do a test recording in your DAW — check levels, room sound, mic placement
 - Experiment: 12th fret vs soundhole vs 45-degree angle on guitar

★ *Mic placement matters more than almost anything else for acoustic guitar tone.*

Record the Single

- Record 3–5 full takes of your single
 - Option A (together): Guitar + vocals at once — more natural feel, less fixable
 - Option B (separate): Guitar first, then vocal — tighter control, more flexibility
- Listen back on headphones AND laptop speakers — both matter
- Pick your best full take as the base — resist over-comping
- Add harmony on chorus only if it serves the song (optional)
- Save all sessions with clear filenames: SingleName_v1_main.wav

Content & Platform

- Post YouTube video #2 — another original or a brief 'what I'm working on' update
- Post YouTube video #3 — a cover of a well-known folk song
- ★ *Covers of known songs bring in new listeners. Originals convert them to fans.*
- Send your FIRST email to your list — introduce yourself, link to YouTube
 - Keep it warm: 'Hey, I'm Jeffrey. Here's what I'm building...'
- Add a 'Something is coming...' teaser to your website home page

◆ **MILESTONE: Single recorded — raw tracks complete**

M3

October 2026 | Mix, Master & Prep for Release

5–7 hrs/wk

Mixing the Single

- Rough mix in your DAW — get vocal and guitar balanced before anything else
 - Acoustic guitar EQ: high-pass at 80Hz, small boost at 2–5kHz for clarity
 - Vocal EQ: high-pass at 100Hz, presence boost at 3–5kHz, de-ess if needed
- Add light reverb to vocals (room or plate, short decay — folk stays dry)
- Add subtle reverb to guitar (just enough to sit in space)
- Check your mix in mono — if it sounds good in mono, it'll translate everywhere
- Option: Hire an online mixer on Fiverr (\$50–\$150) if you want a second ear

★ *Do NOT over-produce. Acoustic folk should sound like a real room, not studio pop.*

Mastering

- Master the single using LANDR (\$9/mo) or hire (\$30–\$60)
- Target loudness: -14 LUFS (Spotify and Apple normalize anyway)
- Export final master as 24-bit WAV
- Listen on 3 devices: headphones, laptop speakers, phone speaker

Release Preparation

- Create single cover art — 3000x3000px minimum (Canva is fine)
 - Must be readable at thumbnail size. Your name + song title visible.
- Get a proper artist photo if you haven't — you'll use this everywhere for a year
- Upload single to DistroKid — set release date 3 WEEKS from submission
 - Release date recommendation: first or second Tuesday of November
- Submit to Spotify editorial playlists via Spotify for Artists — must be 7+ days before release
 - Pitch: genre (acoustic folk/Americana), mood (intimate, reflective), instruments
- Create a pre-save link (DistroKid has this built in)
- Post YouTube video #4 — a behind-the-single or raw recording session clip

◆ **MILESTONE: Single submitted to DistroKid + Spotify editorial pitch sent**

M4

November 2026 | SINGLE RELEASE + EP Pre-Production

5–7 hrs/wk

Release Week

- **RELEASE DAY** — your single goes live on Spotify, Apple Music, YouTube Music, and 30+ platforms
- Send release announcement email — personal, excited, with direct streaming link
 - Subject line idea: 'It's out — my first single' (simple beats clever)
- Post YouTube video #5 — dedicated acoustic performance of the single
- Post on Instagram: photo + caption + streaming link
- Text close friends and family individually with the link (not a mass post)

★ *Ask people to SAVE the song on Spotify (heart icon). Saves matter more than streams for the algorithm.*

Post-Release Push (Weeks 2–4)

- Submit to indie playlist curators via SubmitHub (\$15–\$30 for 10–15 curators)
 - Target playlists: 'acoustic folk', 'singer-songwriter', 'indie folk', 'Americana'
- Reach out to Sandpoint Reader arts editor — brief pitch + streaming link
- Email 3–5 smaller acoustic folk blogs with a personal pitch
- Post YouTube video #6 — a cover of a folk classic
- Post YouTube video #7 — 'story behind the song' for your single
- Check Spotify for Artists: streams, saves, listener locations — note patterns

EP Pre-Production Begins

- Choose your EP track list — 4 or 5 songs
 - Recommended flow: opener (energetic) → 2 mid-tempo → 1 slow/emotional → closer
- Create arrangement sheets for each track: key, tempo, chord chart, structure
- Record scratch demos of all EP candidates (phone recording is fine)
- Make production notes for each: what instrumentation serves the song?

◆ **MILESTONE: First single live on all streaming platforms**

◆ **MILESTONE: 10 YouTube videos published**

EP Planning

- Finalize EP song order — listen to all rough demos in sequence, check the flow
- Write detailed production notes for each track
- Choose an EP title (or shortlist 2–3 options)
- Set your recording schedule for Jan–Feb — block specific sessions per song
- Decide: all tracks solo guitar+vocal, or will any need added elements?

★ *Less is more on a debut EP. Spare arrangements record faster and sound better.*

Holiday Content Opportunity

- Post YouTube video #8 — holiday or winter-themed original OR acoustic holiday cover

★ *Holiday covers get 300–500% search spike in December. Great for discoverability.*

- Post YouTube video #9 — year-end wrap or 'what's coming in 2027' update
- Send year-end email: thank your list, tease the EP coming in spring

Platform Housekeeping

- Review YouTube analytics — which video got the most views? Most watch time?
- Update website: add single to Music page with Spotify embed
- Ensure email signup is prominent on every website page
- Set up link-in-bio tool (Linktree or Beacons, free) for Instagram
- Check DistroKid: confirm royalties routing to your bank account
- **Register with ASCAP (\$50 one-time) or BMI (free)** — do this NOW if you haven't

★ *ASCAP/BMI = performance royalties. You cannot retroactively claim them. Don't wait.*

Recording

- Record EP Track 1 — full guitar + vocal, plus any overdubs
 - Session flow: 1 hr setup/warmup → 2 hrs tracking → 1 hr rough listen
 - Record 3–4 takes minimum, pick the best, comp only if necessary
- Record EP Track 2 — same process
- Export rough mixes of both tracks at end of month — listen on your phone
- Save DAW sessions with version numbers: EP_Track1_Jan15_v2

★ *Don't mix as you go. Track everything first, mix later. It's faster and sounds better.*

Content

- Post YouTube video #10 — channel now has 10 videos (real milestone for credibility)
- Post YouTube video #11 — 'I'm recording my EP' behind-the-scenes
- Send an email: 'EP recording has started — here's what's coming'

Business

- Confirm ASCAP or BMI registration — register each released song
- Start a monthly tracking spreadsheet: Spotify listeners, YouTube subs, email list size
 - Log on the 1st of every month — you'll want this data later
- Research sync licensing: watch 1–2 YouTube explainers on how it works
 - Platforms to bookmark: Musicbed, Artlist, Pond5, Music Vine

M7

February 2027 | EP Recording — Tracks 3, 4 & 5

5–7 hrs/wk

Recording

- Record EP Track 3
 - Record EP Track 4
 - Record EP Track 5 (or use this time to re-record anything from Tracks 1–4)
 - Full playback session: listen to all rough mixes in order, take notes
 - What's the loudest moment? Quietest? Does the EP breathe?
 - Identify any tracks needing additional recording (harmony, re-take, extra element)
- ★ *If you're not happy with a take, re-record now. Mixing can't fix a weak performance.*

Content

- Post YouTube video #12 — acoustic performance of a song that didn't make the EP
- Post YouTube video #13 — short behind-the-scenes recording clip
- Email update: 'Almost done tracking — EP release coming this spring'

EP Art & Packaging

- Decide on EP title (deadline: end of this month)
 - Start cover art concept — sketch ideas, collect reference images
 - Option: hire a Sandpoint photographer for EP shoot (\$75–\$150)
 - Option: use Canva with a strong folk-aesthetic design concept
 - Write 2–3 sentence descriptions for each EP track
- ◆ **MILESTONE: All EP tracks recorded — tracking phase complete**

M8

March 2027 | Mix All EP Tracks

6–8 hrs/wk

Mixing

- Mix EP Track 1 — start with your most complex track (you'll learn the most)
- Use a reference track: listen to a professionally mixed folk album you love
- Mix EP Tracks 2, 3, 4, and 5
- Check each mix: is the vocal sitting above the guitar? Nothing harsh at 3–5kHz?
- Take breaks while mixing — 90 mins on, 30 mins off (ear fatigue is real)
- Export each mix as 24-bit WAV. Keep all sessions. Never delete raw tracks.

- Option: Hire a mixer on Fiverr for \$50–\$150/track for a professional ear

Content

- Post YouTube video #14 — a reflective performance or story-driven video
- Post YouTube video #15 — 'my home studio setup' or 'gear I use' video
- ★ *Gear/studio videos get strong search traffic and attract fellow musicians.*
- Email update: 'Mixing the EP — release date announcement coming soon'

Cover Art & Press Kit

- Finalize EP cover art — 3000x3000px, print-ready
- Build EP press kit (1–2 page PDF): artist bio, EP title, track list, cover art
- Write EP one-sheet: a short paragraph on the EP's sound and themes
- Update website with 'Coming Soon' EP section + cover art
- ★ *A press kit makes you look professional for blogs, playlists, and venues.*

M9

April 2027 | Master, Submit & Build Hype

6–8 hrs/wk

Mastering

- Master all EP tracks — LANDR or hire (\$20–\$50/track)
- Listen to full EP start to finish on 3 devices: headphones, car, laptop
- Check loudness consistency across all tracks
- Export all final masters as 24-bit WAV at 44.1kHz
- ★ *The EP should feel like one cohesive listening experience, not 5 separate songs.*

Distribution & Release Setup

- Upload EP to DistroKid — set release date 3–4 weeks out (target: early May)
 - Upload all tracks, cover art, track descriptions, metadata
- Submit lead EP single to Spotify editorial (7+ days before release)
- Create pre-save link via DistroKid
- Create Bandcamp page — upload EP for \$7+ name-your-price
- Set up Spotify for Artists with EP bio and artist pick

Release Campaign

- Email your list: EP announcement with release date + pre-save link
- Post YouTube video #16 — official EP announcement (performance + talking to camera)
- Post YouTube video #17 — full acoustic performance of one EP track as preview
- Post on Instagram: EP cover art reveal
- Submit to 15–20 playlist curators on SubmitHub (\$20–\$30)
- Email 3–5 acoustic folk blogs with press kit + preview link
- Pitch Sandpoint Reader for a local artist feature
- ★ *One article in the Sandpoint Reader is worth more than 50 Instagram posts.*

◆ **MILESTONE: EP mastered and submitted for distribution**

M1
0

May 2027 | EP RELEASE — Your Debut is Live

5–7 hrs/wk

Release Week

- **EP RELEASE DAY** — 4–5 tracks live everywhere: Spotify, Apple, Bandcamp, and more
 - Send EP release email — personal, warm, direct link
 - Subject: 'My debut EP is out today'
 - Post YouTube video #18 — EP release day performance of your favorite track
 - Post on Instagram: release day + cover art + caption
 - Text close friends and family individually (not a mass message)
- ★ *Ask your email list to share with one person who might enjoy it. Organic sharing > ads.*

Post-Release Momentum

- Post YouTube video #19 — performance of a second EP track
- Post YouTube video #20 — behind the EP: story of making it
- Week 2 email: share early reactions or a favorite recording moment
- Submit to more curators: indie folk, PNW music blogs, Idaho music press
- Sandpoint Farmers Market season is open — apply if you haven't

Start Gigging (Optional — Now You Have a Credential)

- Reach out to Pend d'Oreille Winery and Eichardt's with EP + press kit
 - Consider a simple EP release show — house concert, café, or free outdoor set
- ★ *You now have a real EP. This is your credential for every venue going forward.*

◆ **MILESTONE: Debut EP released on all platforms**

M1
1

June 2027 | Build on Momentum + Sync Licensing

4–6 hrs/wk

Content — Peak Discovery Season

- Summer = peak. Keep YouTube consistent: 1 video every 10 days minimum
 - Post YouTube video #21 — outdoor performance (Sandpoint/lake backdrop)
 - Post YouTube video #22 — a cover with your own arrangement
 - Post YouTube video #23 — 'how I wrote [song]' or songwriting process
- ★ *Outdoor performance videos with beautiful Sandpoint scenery perform extremely well.*

Sync Licensing — Start the Clock

- Create account on Musicbed.com — read submission guidelines thoroughly
- Create account on Artlist.io

- Submit 2–3 of your strongest EP tracks to each platform
 - Write metadata: mood tags (reflective, hopeful), tempo, instruments
 - Catalog all songs with: title, key, tempo, mood, status
- ★ *Sync licensing is slow to pay but fully passive once placed. Start the clock now.*

Live Performance

- Aim for 1–2 booked gigs this month
- Film every performance — even on your phone (content for weeks)
- Collect emails at shows: 'Want to hear when new music drops?'

Monthly Analytics Check

- Log: YouTube subs, Spotify monthly listeners, email list size, total streams
- Which EP track is getting the most streams? That's your marketing priority.
- Which YouTube video got the most views? Make more like that.

M1
2

July 2027 | Year 1 Review + Plan Year 2

3–5 hrs/wk

Year 1 Review

- Pull all Year 1 numbers: total Spotify streams, YouTube subscribers, email list size
 - Calculate total income from all sources (streaming, gigs, Bandcamp, tips)
 - Review 20+ YouTube videos — which 3 performed best and why?
 - Review email list — which emails got the best open rates?
 - Write an honest assessment: what worked, what didn't, what surprised you
- ★ *Most musicians quit in year 1. Finishing this plan puts you ahead of 90% of starters.*

Year 2 Planning

- Decide Year 2 focus: more singles? Full album? Double down on YouTube?
- Set new targets:
 - YouTube: 200–500 subscribers
 - Spotify: 500–2,000 monthly listeners
 - Email list: 150–300 subscribers
- Map out your next 3 releases — singles, covers, or EP tracks as individual releases
- Research online music communities: folk subreddits, acoustic forums, local groups
- Evaluate whether to add online lessons as an income stream (\$50–\$75/hr)

Celebrate

- You released a single AND an EP in one year at 4–8 hours/week
 - You built a website, YouTube channel, email list, and streaming presence
 - You are an independent recording artist. Act like it.
- ★ *Take a week off. Seriously. Burnout kills more music careers than anything else.*

◆ **MILESTONE: Year 1 complete — review done, Year 2 plan in hand**

Year 2–3 Quarterly Roadmap

After Year 1 you have credentials. The strategy shifts from building to growing and diversifying.

Q1 — Aug–Oct 2027 — Release & Grow

- Release 2 new singles from your existing catalog — each one = a YouTube moment + playlist push
- Submit to 3–4 sync licensing platforms
- Continue consistent YouTube uploads (2 per month minimum)
- Grow email list through gig signups and YouTube calls-to-action

Q2 — Nov 2027–Jan 2028 — YouTube Focus + Community

- Target: 250 YouTube subscribers
- Start a consistent series: 'Songs from Sandpoint' or 'Weekly Session'
- First holiday content round (covers + originals)
- Evaluate Patreon or 'buy me a coffee' supporter model

Q3 — Feb–Apr 2028 — Second EP + Festival Applications

- Pre-produce and begin recording your second EP or mini-album
- Apply to 2–3 PNW regional festivals for summer 2028 (Treefort, NW Folk, etc.)
- Expand sync catalog — submit all back catalog with proper metadata

Q4 — May–Jul 2028 — Regional Expansion

- Add Coeur d'Alene and Spokane to gig circuit
- Email list target: 200+ subscribers
- YouTube monetization eligibility: 1K subs + 4K watch hours
- Consider offering 5–8 online music lessons per week (\$50–\$75/hr)

Year 3 — 2028–2029 — Monetize & Scale

- YouTube ad revenue begins
- Sync licensing placements start generating passive income
- Online lesson income: \$200–\$600/month
- Regional touring: Bozeman, Missoula, Portland day trips
- Target: \$600–\$1,500/month combined income
- Evaluate: stay part-time or go deeper?

Master Setup Checklist

Everything you need to set up, in priority order. 'Month 1' items should be done in August. 'At Release' items can wait until your single or EP drops.

Set Up in Month 1 (August 2026)

- **DistroKid** — \$22/yr — music distribution to all streaming platforms
- **Bandzoogle website** — ~\$10/mo — your permanent online home
- **MailerLite email list** — free to 500 subscribers — most valuable audience asset
- **YouTube channel** — free — primary video platform for folk/acoustic
- **Instagram account** — free — claim handle, post lightly
- **Canva account** — free — cover art, banners, social graphics
- **LANDR mastering** — ~\$9/mo — auto-mastering (genuinely good for acoustic)
- **Linktree or Beacons** — free — link-in-bio routing to all platforms

Set Up Before First Release (October 2026)

- **Spotify for Artists** — free — claim after DistroKid submission
- **Apple Music for Artists** — free — useful listener data
- **SubmitHub** — pay per submission — playlist and blog outreach
- **ASCAP (\$50) or BMI (free)** — performance royalties — cannot backdate, register NOW

Set Up at EP Release (May 2027)

- **Bandcamp** — free (15% fee) — folk fans love direct purchases
- **Musicbed / Artist** — free to submit — sync licensing (passive income)